

1. Overview

Summary

The purpose of this document is to present the framework for anticipatory action (AA) for drought in Guatemala, Honduras and El Salvador (Dry Corridor), including the forecasting trigger (the model), the pre-agreed action plans (the delivery) and the pre-arranged financing (the money).

This document should be read in conjunction with the *Anticipatory Action Concept Note* for the Dry Corridor.

Executive summary

This document presents the conceptual framework for collective and pilot anticipatory action in the Dry Corridor. It includes pre-agreed arrangements for forecasts and triggers, an action plan and budgeting. This framework is meant to be a guiding umbrella framework to support countries in developing their country-specific anticipatory action drought frameworks in Central America. Adjustments at country level may include for example national forecast sources, the trigger windows according to local agricultural seasonality, and the selection of context-specific anticipatory actions.

El Nino phenomenon is one of the most serious threats facing the Dry Corridor, with significant impacts on the economy and people's livelihoods. The concept note for this framework outlines plans to implement anticipatory action ahead of an expected drought. This choice is explained, on the one hand, by the considerable number of people whose living conditions will be affected and, on the other, by the availability of proven drought prediction tools.

The aim of this framework is to minimize humanitarian needs in an anticipatory manner through a package of multi-sectoral activities for people at risk of drought impacts in 3 countries likely to be affected. As soon as the triggering threshold is reached (in one or more communes), activity packages will be implemented to meet the needs of the population at risk.

Crisis timeline: Climatically, the dry corridor experiences periods of rain and drought that are associated with seasonal increases in humanitarian needs. For example, the rainy season coincides with the lean season, and therefore with humanitarian needs, as food stocks are almost exhausted from the previous harvest. For this AA Framework, the partners established a crisis chronology to answer the questions: How does a severe drought impact the intensity and timing of humanitarian needs within the Dry corridor? What actions are required and when to minimize the needs?

The trigger model adopted for decision-making in this framework was developed in partnership with FAO (Food and Agriculture Organization), WFP (World Food Programme), UNICEF (United Nations Children's Fund), Pan American Health Organization (PAHO/WHO) and the OCHA (Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs) Center for Humanitarian Data (CHD). The framework considers two trigger "windows" for packages of anticipatory interventions.

OCHA's CHD will monitor seasonal forecasts data. UN Agencies will lead the targeting with a set timeframe and criteria.

Financing. CERF (Central Emergency Response Fund) has pre-arranged up to 10.5 million USD for the implementation of drought anticipatory actions in the Dry Corridor. Based on the regional framework approved by the Emergency Relief Coordinator with annexes for each country, CERF will make the disbursement once the trigger threshold has been reached. Receipt of CERF funding for anticipatory action does not preclude (or guarantee) additional CERF funding for a complementary rapid response to save lives resulting from the same (or other) shocks.

Anticipatory actions. UN agencies have identified anticipatory actions in the following sectors: Food security (food and livelihoods/agriculture), Nutrition, WASH and Health. These actions are detailed below. All activities should start once the triggering threshold has been reached. Cross-cutting protection and accountability aspects have also been considered.

The sectors prioritized for assistance are (in bracket, the implementing agency):

- 1) Food Security (food): \$3.8 million (WFP)
- 2) Food Security (livelihoods/agriculture): \$3.3 million (FAO)
- 3) WASH and Nutrition: \$2.25 million (UNICEF)
- 4) Health: \$1.15 million (WHO / PAHO)

In case of activation, resources will be given to the participating countries as follows:

- Honduras: \$4 million
- Guatemala: \$4 million
- El Salvador: \$2.5 million

The allocations by country, sector and agency are shown in the tables below (data in \$).

<i>Guatemala</i>			
WFP	FAO	UNICEF	WHO
1,600,000	1,200,000	800,000	400,000

<i>Honduras</i>			
WFP	FAO	UNICEF	WHO
1,600,000	1,200,000	800,000	400,000

<i>El Salvador</i>			
WFP	FAO	UNICEF	WHO
600,000	900,000	650,000	350,000

2. Introduction

Objectives of anticipatory action within the Dry Corridor

The aim of this anticipatory action framework is to reduce the humanitarian impact of drought on people at risk in the Dry Corridor through a multi-sectoral package of projects that unfold as soon as the trigger threshold is reached.

In other words, once a severe drought is forecasted, UN Agencies and their partners, including governments, will reach vulnerable people identified within the dry corridor's most vulnerable areas to drought before the humanitarian impact of the shock through a multi-sectoral intervention package.

This anticipatory action package therefore methodically combines "three plus one" components agreed in advance, comprising 3 core elements, all of which are underpinned by a clear learning, monitoring and evaluation plan:

- A robust forecasting embedded in a clear decision-making process (the model).
- Pre-agreed action plans that can fundamentally alter the trajectory of the crisis (the delivery).
- Pre-arranged finance (the money).

3. Forecast

Drought in the dry corridor

Particularly vulnerable to climate change are the Dry Corridor areas of Guatemala, El Salvador and Honduras. Since 2001, these areas have suffered from irregular drought patterns due to changes in the El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO). Drought impact has been especially severe in Honduras and Guatemala.

El Niño typically leads to below-average rainfall over Central America. An El Niño event aggravates dry conditions by bringing poor spatial and temporal distribution of rains during a critical stage of crop development, often causing a late onset to the rains and/or increased dry spells, an early cessation threatening an already fragile agricultural sector marked by low resilience and inadequate preparedness to handle weather shocks. Areas at highest risk go across the Dry Corridor stretching across Guatemala, Honduras, and El Salvador, including also Atlantic-facing regions and northern Guatemala.

El Niño-related drought typically intensifies and **increases the needs for humanitarian assistance in the region**. Potential impacts of concern include rising food prices, increase in malnutrition – in a region where, despite low prevalence, an increase in cases of acute malnutrition has been reported recently - and heightened protection concerns, particularly for vulnerable groups¹.

¹IASC – Early Warning, Early Action and Readiness Analysis - Monthly Horizon Scanning Brief March 2023

In context of drought, the overall **nutritional intake decreases**, and poor households are at higher risk to suffer multiple **micronutrient deficits**, contributing to higher prevalence of underweight and stunting among children under five (especially for reduced ability to access food, particularly animal-sourced foods high in caloric energy, protein, and fat).

During droughts, **access to water is reduced both in terms of quantity and quality** - at home, in schools and in health-care-facilities – increasing the risk of spreading respiratory diseases, and acute diarrheal diseases (such as cholera, typhoid) and other **water-borne diseases**, especially in children living in unplanned urban dwellings. Remaining productive water points are more vulnerable to contamination and are used by a growing number of people, and the risk of over-abstraction can foster **tensions between users**. The increase of diseases is reinforced by poor sanitation and hygiene practices, compounded by the proliferation of **vector-borne diseases** in unsafe environments (including Zika, yellow fever, dengue, etc.).

Gender inequities intensify during droughts. Water scarcity affects menstrual hygiene in young girls and women, while children (often responsible for collecting the water) spend **less time at school**, with an enormous burden aggravated by higher exposure to safety risks and exploitation while fetching water. During the last prolonged drought recorded in Honduras (2016-2020), one in four people reported an increase in violence during the emergency, including an increased risk for children and an even more pronounced risk for girls (37%) than boys (17%). Moreover, poor nutrition can impact the school **performance of students**, their motivation to attend school, and acquisition of knowledge and skills necessary to advance. The disruption of education and the lack of a **safe and protective environment** for children amplifies their risk of exposure to violence and other risks, especially those whose families have been fragmented due to internal displacement or migration.

Droughts also affect **poverty, violence, and migration**. The poorest households in areas of the Honduran, El Salvadoran, Guatemalan Dry Corridor of the Western Altiplano and Alta Verapaz, are considered the most at-risk since they have seen their livelihoods deteriorate and have been forced to employ unsustainable coping strategies until the arrival of the first harvest in September. El Niño is expected to further **affect the capability of vulnerable households to access quality services**, including indigenous groups.

Poorest households suffer a **significant narrowing of income generation** options, which leads to high-risk activities that can lead to progressive draining of economic assets and stocks and increasing inequality and marginalization for the most vulnerable. Children are most at risk of being left with limited or no access to the essential services and may be forced into child labor to compensate for loss of agriculture and livelihoods. This change in livelihoods can produce an **increase of insecurity**, especially for women and children, with increased risk of being exposed to internal or international migration, exploitation and abuse, including sexually, as extreme survival strategies, with further **limitation of children attending schools**, due to the households needs for economic support and an increased risk of child labor and exploitation.

Seasonal calendar

	YEAR 1												YEAR 2												
	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	
Cycle in 'normal' years																									
Rainfall & Dry Season	Dry				Rain		Dry	Rain				Dry					Rain			Dry	Rain				Dry
Harvest									H. Primera												H. Primera				
Lean Season																									
Potential impact of drought (IF below-average rainfall in Year 1)																									
Drought-Induced Hunger																									
Maize (main crop Primera)																									
Beans (main crop Postrema)																									
Depletion in livestock condition																									
Increase of communicable, diarrheal, vector-borne and acute respiratory diseases																									
Water unavailability																									
Rise in malnutrition																									

Impact	
Low	
Moderate	
High	

4. Anticipatory Action Plan

Selection criteria

Anticipatory actions will aim to interrupt the pathways outlined in the crisis timeline section above by targeting populations most at risk of being impacted by a shock. The following criteria were applied to select actions:

1. **Anticipatory character:** Is the action effective in preventing or reducing the humanitarian impact of the shock?
2. **Ability to deliver within the window of opportunity:** Is it possible to carry out the action effectively with the available forecast lead time², i.e. in the window of opportunity?
3. **Operational capacity:** Do the agency and its implementing partners have the institutional capacity (thematic, logistic, administrative, financial, human resources) to implement the action effectively given the lead time and scale?
4. **No regrets approach:** In the case of a false alarm, will the proposed actions benefit, rather than harm, the targeted population?

In principle, the activities under window A and window B form two collective packages. Activities under one window will be activated together, targeting the same populations. Some activities are particularly time-critical and have minimum lead times (defined as the time between initiation of the project and the beginning of delivery of assistance to the population). Activities whose lead time does not permit timely delivery of assistance if activation occurs in a later monitoring month, shall be labelled as such in the framework and CERF projects.

CERF cannot fund activities that are no longer feasible at the moment of triggering, according to the lead times provided in the country-specific annexes. In case of 'late activation' (i.e. after the latest feasible time, as per Agencies' provided information), project budgets will be reduced accordingly.

Priority interventions

The pre-agreed actions will focus on the following core objectives:

- Advising small-holder farmers on appropriate decisions to take before and during drought, based on agroclimatic information
- Protecting food production, productive assets and access to food, through inputs distribution, water harvesting, cash injections and good agricultural practices [Food Security – FAO & WFP]
- Mitigating the risk of acute malnutrition in children under 5 years of age, ensuring early identification and referral to life-saving treatment (reinforce surveillance, prepositioning of supplies, mobilization to ensure community-based access the services) [Nutrition - Unicef]
- Protecting the access to safe water and hygiene practices, including in health facilities and schools (water sources protection/rehabilitation, water storage supplies distribution, chemicals distribution for water quality, awareness raising on water and hygiene management) [WASH – Unicef]
- Preventing acute malnutrition, epidemic outbreaks and health care associated infections through comprehensive nutritional surveillance, control and containment of epidemic outbreaks of infectious and communicable diseases [Health – WHO]
- Contain epidemic outbreaks of infectious and communicable diseases by strengthening of monitoring systems, collection, storage and supply of water in health and sanitary facilities [Health – WHO]

The summary table provides a snapshot of each agency's proposed activity. Further details can be found in CERF application documents (project proposals and budgets).

² Lead time is defined as the time between initiation of the project and the beginning of delivery of assistance to the population.

Implementation timeline

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Seasons (dry/wet)	Dry				Primera season		Dry	Postrera season			Dry	
Window A (trigger monitoring period)												
Window A (forecasted months)												
Dissemination of forecasts and early warning message, with technical advice to farmers				X	X							
Quick impact training on climate-smart agricultural, water management practices				X	X	X	X					
Distribution of drought-tolerant staple grains seeds, and fertilizers					X							
Distribution of inputs for vegetable and poultry production					X	X	X					
Unconditional multipurpose cash to protect livelihood and other essential needs				X	X	X						
Rehabilitation or construction of water sources & water distribution points (including rainwater gathering systems)				X	X	X						
Training to communities on risk reduction for water and sanitation related diseases					X	X	X					
Dissemination of messages for prevention of malnutrition and safe water management in drought situations				X	X	X	X					
Nutrition screenings and surveillance (and supply of tailored nutritional prepositioned materials)					X	X	X					
Training to technicians to support malnutrition surveillance and awareness raising				X	X	X	X					
Distribution of equipment, supplies and training to efficiently contain epidemic outbreaks quickly				X	X	X						
Delivery of mitigation messages to vulnerable population to cope with drought-related health risks				X	X	X	X					
Equip and train health technicians to carry out water quality monitoring and install water storage systems in sanitary facilities.				X	X	X						
Window B (monitoring)												
Window B (forecasted/trigger window)												
Dissemination of forecasts and early warning message, with technical advice to farmers							X	X	X			
Distribution of short-cycle seeds with fertilizers									X			
Vaccination and animal health campaigns								X	X			
Distribution of animal feed (MNB, mineralized blocks, fodder)							X	X				
Unconditional multipurpose cash to protect livelihood and other essential needs								X	X			
Rehabilitation of water sources (wells, rainwater collection systems)							X	X	X			
Training to communities on risk reduction for water and sanitation related diseases								X	X			
Dissemination of messages for prevention of malnutrition and safe water management in drought situations									X		X	

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Seasons (dry/wet)	Dry				Primera season			Dry	Postrera season			Dry
Nutrition screenings and surveillance (and supply of tailored nutritional prepositioned materials)											X	X
Training to technicians to support malnutrition surveillance and awareness raising								X	X		X	
Distribution of equipment, supplies and training to efficiently contain epidemic outbreaks quickly								X	X			
Delivery of mitigation messages to vulnerable population to cope with drought-related health risks								X	X		X	
Equip and train health technicians to carry out water quality monitoring and install water storage systems in sanitary facilities.								X	X			

Triggers and thresholds

WINDOWS: monitoring period (orange) & forecasted period (blue)³ in between period (Green)

Window A

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
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Window B

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
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Trigger window & timing	Indicator	Source	Trigger
Window A (March-May) Primera	MJJA Seasonal Forecast	National forecast (whenever possible/available) or ECMWF*	MJJA precipitation <= 1 in 4-year RP
Window B (June-August) Postrera	SON Seasonal Forecast	National forecast (whenever possible/available) or ECMWF*	SON precipitation <= 1 in 4-year RP

* In case of discrepancies between national and ECMWF forecast, the former will be used

OCHA's CHD will monitor seasonal forecasts.

Roles and responsibilities in monitoring the trigger

The triggers will be monitored by OCHA's Centre for Humanitarian Data (CHD). Once the trigger is reached, during any of the potential trigger months, the CHD provides an alert by e-mail (see detailed activation protocol below).

Activation protocol

The predefinition of an activation protocol is essential to avoid delays when a trigger threshold is reached. The activation protocol describes the specific steps to be taken as soon as one of the triggers is reached.

Organization	Activity	Medium	Timeline
CHD	Monitoring of rainfall forecast data & validation	N/A	Monthly
CHD	Release of forecast analysis with relevant offices, including information "trigger reached/not reached"	Email update from CHD to "core group", with attached analysis	Within 1 day of forecast publication
OCHA HAT (on behalf of the RC/HC)	If trigger is reached, arrange country-level meetings with partners to validate forecast analysis (UN agency country & regional focal points, representative from respective government met agency)	Online meeting	2 days

³ May is a month that both 'monitors' and 'is monitored'. Hence, its odd color of green. In May, CHD will look at the forecast of MJJA. It is still possible for the framework to trigger in May.

Organization	Activity	Medium	Timeline
OCHA HAT (on behalf of the RC/HC)	Submit outcome of validation meeting: "validation agreement/disagreement"	Email from each HAT to "core group" (in case of disagreement attach relevant meteorological reports)	1 day
CERF secretariat & agency HQs	Send approval letters to concerned agencies and initiate fund disbursement upon receipt of counter-signed letters ⁴	Email w/ letters usual process, "core group" in CC	2 days

It is worth noting that the three countries will follow parallel, yet separate activation and monitoring streams. Activation points differ from country to country, so do weather forecasts. Hence, one country could potentially reach activation point in a given month, and another country in the following month (or, not reaching it at all). The result is, possibly, a scattered activation.

Monitoring of Triggers

For transparency and accountability, CHD will keep informed concerned stakeholders (OCHA Country and Regional Offices, Agencies Country and Regional Offices, OCHA NY [CERF, OAD, HFSA]) throughout the monitoring periods/windows, regardless of the achievements of trigger-point or not. Upon receipt of an alert from CHD on possible activation, a meeting will be convened at country level, under the leadership of the RC/HC, to discuss the results.

In the unlikely event that CHD communicates the reaching of trigger-point for a country, but in-country stakeholders disagree (opting for a 'non-activation'), the RC/HC will notify agency focal points and OCHA NY (CERF, OAD, HFSA) about the decision to not activate the framework.

It is important to note that, in case of non-activation, other funding mechanisms are available from CERF, including the Rapid Response for Early Action. Hence, a no-activation does not preclude the mobilization of resources from other mechanisms.

Targeting

Each country defines its targeting based on a model that encompasses a geographical scope for identifying areas most affected by drought, and a people's approach that identifies the most vulnerable people within those areas. This is described in the respective country annex.

Implementing agencies will proactively seek synergies and complementary actions to assist the same communities, and possibly the same households, with most of the services included in the present framework. The rationale will be to provide comprehensive and complementary anticipatory assistance to families and communities, with the objective of mitigating the drought's effect.

By having the same communities (or families) assisted with most, if not all, the thematic areas included in the framework (food security, nutrition, water, sanitation, hygiene and health), it is expected that this holistic delivery will result in synergetic outcomes amongst the thematic areas and obtaining multiplier effects.

The area identified by the countries for interventions are as follows (Departments and, in brackets, the selected municipalities):

Country	Departments
El Salvador	San Vicente (San Vicente and Tecoluca)
Honduras	El Paraíso (Texiguat, Vado Ancho) and Francisco Morazán (Curarén, Alubarén, Reitoca)
Guatemala	Chiquimula (San Jacinto, Jocotán, Camotán, San Juan Ermita, Chiquimula, San José La Arada, Concepción Las Minas, Olopa, Quezaltepeque y Esquipulas)

⁴ In principle, the activities under window A and window B form two collective packages. Activities under one window will be activated together, targeting the same populations. Some activities are particularly time-critical and have minimum lead times (defined as the time between initiation of the project and the beginning of delivery of assistance to the population). Activities whose lead time does not permit timely delivery of assistance if activation occurs in a later monitoring month, shall be labelled as such in the framework and CERF projects. In case of activation during a month that renders the successful implementation of the activity unfeasible, the CERF project and budget shall be reduced accordingly at the moment of activation and before funding disbursement.

Ensuring readiness for a timely implementation

UN Agencies have established presence at regional, subregional and country base levels, including sound relationships with ministries of agriculture, national Disaster Risk Management (DRM) systems and other relevant national and subregional institutions. As well, FAO and WFP have Anticipatory Action Plans for Drought in Honduras, Guatemala and El Salvador, including funding from ECHO.

5. Pre-agreed Financing

Pre-arranged finance to fuel anticipatory action is critical to enable timely, effective anticipatory action. A key recommendation from the Emergency Relief Coordinator is to find co-financing for coordinated anticipatory action in the Dry Corridor to ensure available funding is mutually reinforcing. Of course, partner agencies invest considerable resources in building coordinated anticipatory action, but also for preparedness already.

CERF

For the anticipatory action framework in the Dry Corridor, the ERC (Emergency Relief Coordinator) agreed to pre-arrange up to \$10.5 million from CERF for two years (2024-2025). Funding will be disbursed, if the above-outlined triggers are reached.

All funds will be disbursed through CERF's Rapid Response window; CERF has not created a separate "Anticipatory Action" window.

CERF will disburse funds once three conditions are met:

- Endorsement by the relevant Resident/Humanitarian Coordinator of the country-specific Anticipatory Action validation protocol and the CERF application package comprising agency-specific project proposals and agency-specific budgets.
- Endorsement by the Emergency Relief Coordinator of the country-specific Anticipatory Action framework and the CERF application package comprising agency-specific project proposals and agency-specific budgets (this can be a pre-agreed endorsement).
- Activation of the pre-agreed trigger threshold, within a maximum of two years from the ERC's endorsement of the framework.

Other donors

This framework for anticipatory action is not limited to CERF-funded activities. There are various instruments, including the World Bank's Crisis Response Window (CRW), Education Cannot Wait (ECW), Start Network, bilateral donors and UN agencies' internal reserve funds that can, within their own established criteria and in complementarity, finance part of this plan when the need arises.

The following donors/partners who have pre-committed funding that it is aligned to this plan:

- ECHO [0.9 million EUR]
- WFP internal funding [1- 1,5 million USD]
- FAO internal funding [1 million USD]

6. Learning

Monitoring

Post-distribution monitoring (PDM) will be done by UN agencies under the AA framework, in coordination with implementing partners and relevant stakeholders, to measure results achievement.

Each agency will use its existing monitoring and evaluation systems to collect and track data on implementation progress and results achieved. This can be financed by CERF funds as usual. All results will be shared.

To ensure robust evidence with causal attribution to AA, each implementing agency is encouraged, wherever possible to use a comparative research design in their M&E plan to estimate what would have happened without anticipated actions (the "counterfactual"). In practical terms, this means that in addition to collecting outcome indicator data from AA

beneficiaries, outcome data should also be collected from a comparison group made up of individuals/households who share the same socio-economic characteristics and are also affected by drought as the intervention group receiving AA. Examples of relevant comparison groups could be individuals/households who receive "no assistance", "no AA but only a post-shock response", or who receive different configurations of the planned AA package, for example by varying the transfer amount/reduction/complementary actions. It is up to each implementing agency to determine whether this kind of study is feasible and practical in its operational context.

At a minimum, and to enable maximum learning, each agency's M&E will need to integrate and report on a set of common questions, including:

- What was the impact of anticipatory activities on the survival or quality of life of beneficiaries?
- Was the assistance provided in time, ahead of the crisis, in line with the anticipatory nature of the framework? Did the timing make a difference?
- Can we draw a comparison between anticipatory activities in the framework, and past response interventions?
- Can we draw a comparison between communities receiving anticipatory activities, and those not receiving?
- Did activities result in any multiplier or spillover effects?

Reports will be shared with relevant stakeholders, including actions taken to resolve identified implementation issues.

To capitalize on respective technical expertise, and avoid unnecessary, multiple visits to the same communities and households, Agencies will agree on ways to coordinate M&E efforts. Ideally, a comprehensive M&E framework will be agreed at country-level, amongst participating Agencies, including a common form for data capturing, timing, responsibilities. OCHA can facilitate these discussions, and compile learnings from the various sources in one comprehensive document.

Independent evaluation

If possible, the anticipatory action framework will be subject to a final independent evaluation to assess its implementation and the added value of the anticipatory activities, to generate lessons for anticipatory action and improve future operations.

All evaluations will be carried out with the technical support of the sub-regional, regional and global teams of the agencies involved in the process, and in coordination with implementing partners.

7. Annexes

Trigger Mechanism for Anticipatory Action in Central America Dry Corridor (CADC)

Anticipatory Action Framework - Dry Corridor - El Salvador

Anticipatory Action Framework - Dry Corridor – Guatemala

Anticipatory Action Framework - Dry Corridor - Honduras